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Not by Books Alone

Science and maths should be more than a passport to an engineering degree

Recently, the Planning Commission unearthed data that reflected poorly on the education system of our country. Out of all the children that go to school in the country, 40 per cent cannot read a sentence and divide a two-digit number. Seventy to 80 per cent of our children are denied good education at school levels and are dropouts by the time they reach higher education. The syllabus of schools seem to be overloaded with questions that are complex and of little use to better intellectual abilities. To resolve this issue, I would suggest that the Central Government select and support 10 institutions, mainly schools, in the country so that the children are ensured good quality education.

TIRBHU VAN TIWARI

13.5 million

is the number of students who enrolled in higher education institutions in 2007 as against seven million a decade ago.



INSPIRING STUDENTS TO LEARN SCIENCE IS A TEACHER'S PRIME RESPONSIBILITY

► Science is an important aspect of education but is often neglected. It is the responsibility of every teacher to inspire her students to take an avid interest in the subject that she teaches. But this is not often the case. Most students either lose interest in the subject due to the lacklustre performance of teachers or only opt for engineering because of the employment opportunities it offers. There are over 2,500 engineering colleges in the country, but none of them ensure quality education as they do not have

proper faculty or enough funds to set up a world class education system.

► The reason most people don't opt for science at the college level is because they do not have any idea about the kind of employment opportunities it offers in the long run. The Government, on its part, should be able to provide for its young scientists and open research centres in universities. The research laboratories that we have at universities are ill-equipped and lack funds. If a young mind cannot experiment in the subject that he is choosing, he will not benefit at all.

► I understand that the country lacks economic resources, but instead of opening 10 more IITs and IIMs, what the government can focus on is having at least a dozen institutes that are at par with

universities abroad. You cannot improve sciences and maths in isolation without focusing on the entire education system, its mentality and also investing in every child.

► It is heartbreaking to see an educated person with a B. Sc degree reduced to the level of a government peon. Why should a person work so hard, if there are no employment opportunities at the end of his course? I suggest that every job be given not a minimum qualification, but a maximum qualification. Also, there should be a link between the employer and the student. The number of students should be in conjunction with prospects of future employment.

► Many students lag behind in what they do, because of the dull teaching methods or uninspiring teachers in government schools. These teachers are often hired on the basis of reservation policies.

Community reservation does not solve long-term issues. The government should ensure that intelligent children from the community get world-class education. Also, reservation of faculty is a dangerous concept. A poor teacher not only hurts the student but also destroys the institution he works for.

► The higher and middle school syllabus should be relaxed and students be allowed to focus more on the application methods and practical aspects of the subject.

As told to Gunjeet Sra